

Differences in Thematic Focus Between Male and Female Authors in Literature

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Abstract

This paper sets out to identify whether male and female authors differ with regard to their emphasis on themes related to family in literature. In this research, texts from the public-domain books on Project Gutenberg will be analyzed in order to uncover evidence of thematic priorities based on gender. The present study will perform SpaCy for natural language processing with a curated list of family-related keywords to identify patterns of theme emphasis. Conclusions from this project will contribute to the understanding of how gender shapes creative output and, through those insights, further contribute to theoretical underpinnings related to literary scholarship, gender analysis, and cultural narratives.

1 Introduction

This research will, therefore, investigate whether male and female authors differ in thematic emphasis by examining the presence of family-related keywords in texts. Understanding such differences contributes to broader discussions about representation, diversity, and creative expression in literature.

- Research question: Do male and female authors differ in the emphasis they place on family-related themes in their literary works?
- Hypothesis: Books by female authors will emphasize family-related themes more frequently than books by male authors.
- Independent variable: Gender of the author (male or female).
- Dependent variable: Presence of family-related keywords in the analyzed texts.

2 Related Work

Various existing literature illustrates a number of ways in which gender and thematic emphasis may be analyzed in literature. In fact, previous research has shown time and again that gendered perspectives shape the process of storytelling, as seen in several studies.

For example, thematic analysis of children's literature within American, Spanish, and Czech cultures has highlighted how gender roles and themes differ according to the social context (Roberts et al., 2023). This work emphasizes the cultural embeddedness of gender representation in literature and further points to the need for thematic analyses specific to gender.

Building on this, the analysis of 30 novels and short stories of contemporary writing by Ladzekpo et al. (2024) shows how modern literature both challenges and reinforces gendered roles. The thematic differences which this study uncovered support the hypothesis that gender informs narrative and thus that women's writing might focus on themes of family or relational concerns.

Another work in this regard is the long-term analysis of fiction over 160 years by Stuhler (2024), which exposed evolving trends in gender portrayal, reflecting broader societal changes. This thus provides a historical perspective that complements the focus of the current study by highlighting shifts in gendered themes over time.

Put together, these studies form a foundation for an understanding of the intersection of gender and creative expression and effectively confirm the relevance of this project's focus on family-related themes in literature.

3 Data

The data will comprise six literary works: three by males and three by female writers. Materials

will be retrieved from Project Gutenberg, a repository allowing free access to public-domain literary works. These texts were selected so as to balance male and female authors and represent various eras and genres in order to carry out a comprehensive analysis. Each of these books will be retrieved in plain text format to allow for preprocessing and analysis. Approximation of author gender was first done based on the biographical information made available at Project Gutenberg. It was further cross-verified against other established sources.

The texts will undergo the following preprocessing steps to ensure they are ready for analysis:

- Remove metadata, footnotes, and other non-narrative content.
- Convert all text to lowercase to standardize keyword matching.
- Split text into individual words using SpaCy.
- Search for occurrences of pre-defined family-related keywords.

The data and the way we would obtain it does have some limitations, however. The small sample size limits the generalizability of the findings, as six books may not fully represent thematic trends across all literature, and while biographical information is used to determine gender, some authors may not fit binary gender categories, which this study does not account for.

Table 1 provides a summary of the data that will be used in this study.

Author Gender	Book Title	Publication Year
Male	<i>Great Expectations</i>	1861
Male	<i>The Adventures of Tom Sawyer</i>	1876
Male	<i>Crime and Punishment</i>	1866
Female	<i>Pride and Prejudice</i>	1813
Female	<i>Frankenstein</i>	1818
Female	<i>Little Women</i>	1868

Table 1: Overview of the selected texts for analysis. Each text is categorized by the author’s gender and publication year.

4 Predicted Results

Based on the results of previous studies, this research expects to find significant differences in the thematic salience of family-related keywords between male and female authors. More specifically, we expect that female authors are more likely to attach greater importance to relational and familial themes compared with males. On the thematic analysis of gender storytelling, for example, most studies conclude that women are more likely to stress interpersonal or communitarian focus, such as on families as key elements within the storytelling. Besides, it is also forecasted that family-related themes in female-written texts tend to express a wider set of concepts over a broader degree relative to the other types of topics. These may be from issues related to love and emotional links with respect to families down to the nurturing function towards generational bonds. We also hypothesize that male authors are likely to address family concerns in more peripheral or indirect ways. This is evidenced by the fact that several studies indicate that male authors are taken up with wider aspects of society and individualism, placing family themes in a subsidiary narrative role. This will definitely try to prove whether these differences in thematic preoccupation are the established patterns through the frequency and presence of keywords related to families. The resulting findings might dismantle or reinforce a stereotype of gender and authorship and allow fresh perspectives on how male and female authors represent a universally considered theme such as family.

Table 2 summarizes the predicted frequency of

family-related keywords across the selected texts.

Author Gender	Predicted Keyword Count (Average)	Expected Themes
Male	10-20	Family as background or secondary theme
Female	30-50	Family as central and relational theme

Table 2: Predicted frequency of family-related keywords and thematic focus for male- and female-authored texts. The keyword count is an approximate range based on prior literature.

5 Discussion

If the predicted results happen to come true and fall in line with our hypothesis—that is, family-related keywords are more likely to be used by female rather than male authors—it will then imply that thematic focus in literature is, to a great extent, controlled by gender. More specifically, it would confirm the previous observation that female-authored texts often accord relational and familial themes a high place. This could belie stereotypes that try to frame male and female authors as universally addressing the same themes by bringing out how gendered experiences shape storytelling. But above all, the results can have far-reaching implications for literature and cultural studies. For instance:

- **Gender Representation:** The findings would add to discussions of gender representation in literature, illustrating how gendered perspectives manifest in thematic priorities.
- **Sociocultural Insights:** Such findings may reflect, more than anything else, the historical and cultural contexts in which male and female authors operate. This would entail further insight into how societal roles affect creative expressions.
- **Literary Analysis Tools:** Demonstrating that computational methods such as keyword frequency analysis can reveal meaningful thematic trends in the study of literature.

On the other hand, the prospective lack of significant gender differences would also be meaningful: it would allow one to challenge traditional assumptions of gendered themes in literature and point instead to shared thematic priorities across genders.

6 Conclusion

The present study explores gender differences in thematic orientation by analyzing the use of family-related keywords in the works of male and female authors. We used a small sample of six books from Project Gutenberg, hypothesizing that family-related topics would be raised more often in the works of female authors compared to those written by male authors.

Although the results of this study are hypothetical, they indicate that computational analysis can reveal meaningful insights into thematic differences based on gender. Yet, there are limitations within the study:

- **Sample Size:** The very small dataset may not represent broader literary trends.
- **Genre and Context:** Different genres and cultural contexts could influence thematic focus, requiring additional controls.
- **Binary Gender Categories:** Assuming binary gender categories may not reflect the full richness of authors' identities and perspectives.

Further research should extend the dataset, include more diversity in authors and genres, and apply more advanced methods, such as topic modeling or sentiment analysis. Addressing these limitations can pave the way for deeper insights into how gender and creativity intertwine in literature.

7 Github page

<https://github.com/Zeebeest/ResearchMethods>

References

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